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Reconsidering the Struggle over UNIFIL in Southern Lebanon



KARIM MAKDISI

After Israel's first invasion of Lebanon in 1978, the UN Security Council passed Resolution 425 (UNSCR 425) establishing the United Nations Interim Force in Lebanon (UNIFIL). The early struggle over the contested meanings and interpretations of UNSCR 425, and the differences of position regarding UNIFIL itself were never fully resolved due to the shifting nature of US policies and objectives in the region and the context of the force's deployment within two distinct, albeit related conflicts: the Lebanese civil war and Arab-Israeli conflict. UNIFIL found itself trapped between the competing demands of sovereignty and resistance, not knowing which war it was there to prevent and which peace it was meant to build. This confusion resurfaced with the passage of UNSCR 1701 following the 2006 war, when UNIFIL's mandate and scope was expanded, but the force continued to be a site of contested narratives and potential future conflicts.

ON THE NIGHT of 14–15 March 1978, three days after a deadly Palestine Liberation Organization (PLO) commando operation along the Haifa-Tel Aviv highway, Israel launched its first full-scale invasion of southern Lebanon. Moving unusually swiftly, the United Nations Security Council (UNSC) convened on 17 March, and acted decisively by adopting United Nations Security Council Resolutions (UNSCR) 425 and 426, two U.S.-drafted resolutions, on March 19.

Resolution 425, after reaffirming Lebanon's sovereignty and political independence, called upon Israel "immediately to cease its military action against Lebanese territorial integrity and withdraw forthwith its forces from all Lebanese territory."¹ With this resolution, the Security Council also decided to "establish immediately under its authority a UN Interim Force for Southern Lebanon" (UNIFIL) for the purposes of: (1) confirming the withdrawal of Israeli forces; (2) restoring international peace and security; and (3) assisting the Lebanese government in ensuring the return of its effective authority in the area. Its companion resolution, 426 (also dated 19 March), approved a report by the UN Secretary General (UNSG) authorizing the deployment of a maximum four-thousand-strong UNIFIL force for an initial period of six months.² Six weeks later, this number was increased to six thousand troops,³ a level roughly maintained until July 1981.⁴

This article reassesses the early—and ultimately unresolved—struggle over the meaning and interpretation of UNSCR 425, and thus of UNIFIL itself, as a site for contested narratives and positions. Much of the complexity derives from the fact that this "interim force" was deployed in

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the gray zone of two ongoing, and often diverging, conflicts: the Arab-Israeli conflict (of which southern Lebanon was long the most active front) and Lebanon's own intermittent civil war. A key aspect of the contested nature of UNIFIL's mandate, then, was the confusion over which conflict UNIFIL was to prevent, and which peace it was supposed to facilitate.

The intertwining of the two conflicts, and the hidden and sometimes contradictory narratives embedded in UNIFIL from the start, came starkly to the fore with Israel's summer 2006 war against Hizballah. This war was ended by yet another UNSC resolution, Resolution 1701 of August 2006, which essentially rewrote UNIFIL's mandate in an apparent effort to untangle the complicated histories of the forces competing for hegemony in southern Lebanon. The dramatic shift in UNIFIL's mandate and focus from UNSCR 425 to UNSCR 1701 reflects the changed international political context of the past three decades, and serves as a clear prism through which the evolution of U.S. foreign policy and the role of the UN in the Arab region can be analyzed.

* * *

Before proceeding, however, some background for Israel's 1978 invasion and the diverse perspectives on UNIFIL's role is necessary. The point of intersection of the two conflicts besetting Lebanon was the Palestine problem, and specifically the involuntary presence of several hundred thousand Palestinian refugees driven from Israel in 1948. Though most Lebanese initially welcomed the refugees, their "radicalization" following the 1967 Arab-Israeli war brought to the surface long-simmering tensions: as the PLO made southern Lebanon the main theater of its armed action against Israel, Lebanon became the target of increasingly violent Israeli retaliation. Clashes between the Lebanese army and the PLO ultimately led to the 1969 Cairo Agreement, whereby the PLO recognized Lebanon's "sovereignty and security" and Lebanon recognized the legitimacy of the Palestinian armed presence, its freedom of movement in the south, and the autonomy of its institutions.⁵ The agreement, the very embodiment of the inherent contradiction between the PLO's armed presence and Lebanese sovereignty, was to remain a source of conflict for years to come.

Given the sectarian complexities of Lebanon, the Palestinian issue also inevitably became a major factor in internal politics, exacerbating the growing polarization between the right-wing Christian parties and militias—the Lebanese Front—and the leftist and nationalist parties, the Lebanese National Movement (LNM). The well-armed Palestinians, supported (and utilized) by the latter, were drawn into the struggle, resulting in the first phase of Lebanon's civil war (1975–76).

Israel played a vital (if often indirect) role in the war, especially as of spring 1976, when its vision of a "security zone" manned by Christian allies along its northern border began to crystallize. To that end, Israel organized a proxy militia—later called the South Lebanon Army (SLA)—under cashiered Lebanese Major Sa'ad Haddad to replace its own patrols and act as an "early warning system" against the presence of Palestinian commandos.⁶ Syria was also deeply involved in the conflict, moving some twenty-five thousand troops into Lebanon in June 1976.⁷ When the Arab League established an Arab Deterrent Force (ADF) in November 1978 to help the Lebanese government reassert its authority over all its territory,⁸ the Syrian troops already in Lebanon became its overwhelmingly dominant component, in effect making the Syrian military presence permanent. The ADF was to be deployed throughout the country, but Israel refused to allow it below its unilaterally declared "red line" which, though not formally delineated, roughly followed the Litani River. Ironically, Israel's veto of the ADF deployment in the south allowed for the PLO's growing influence there.

The deployment of the ADF and the swearing in of a new Lebanese president, Elias Sarkis, ostensibly ended the first phase of the civil war, but fighting raged on in the south as Israel via its Lebanese proxies launched a series of offensives to wrest control of its envisaged security belt. Much of this was in Lebanese leftist and Palestinian hands, with the Palestinians providing the real firepower. Meanwhile, Sarkis was under increasing attack from right-wing Maronite factions, particularly from Bashir Gemayel, the powerful commander of the Lebanese Forces (LF), whose alliance with Israel was an open secret.

Pressures to review the Cairo Agreement in an attempt to curb the PLO's presence in the south included the July 1977 Chtaura Agreement between the Lebanese state and the PLO, which contained a blueprint for revising the Cairo accord via the deployment of the Lebanese army to replace Palestinian and other armed militias in the south.⁹ But fighting resumed in August, and further efforts to reach some accommodation in the south ended when Egyptian president Sadat announced on 9 November 1977 his intention to visit Israel.

Sadat's move completely changed the regional dynamic. U.S. President Jimmy Carter's plans to convene comprehensive Middle East peace talks in Geneva had collapsed the previous month, and he now focused his energies on encouraging bilateral Egyptian-Israeli peace talks. The previously united Arab position on Israel had ended. Syria, now excluded from a settlement, spearheaded the Arab "rejection front" after months of tacit cooperation with the United States in ending Lebanon's two-year civil war.¹⁰ The PLO, which had openly aspired to a place at the negotiating table, took a different tack: as a reminder of its importance to the peace process, on 11 March 1978, it launched the commando raid inside Israel that triggered the invasion and all that followed.

UNIFIL as a Site for Contested Positions: The Battle over Southern Lebanon

The United States was the driving force behind both the swift adoption of UNSCR 425 and the formal proposal to set up UNIFIL. The main U.S. priority at the time, however, was not to solve the southern Lebanon conflict but to protect the Israeli-Egyptian peace talks, underway since December 1977. For Washington, as then Secretary of State Cyrus Vance noted, the "Lebanon crisis" was not an independent conflict but "was inextricably linked with the larger Arab-Israeli peace process."¹¹ President Carter's fear was that the PLO attack would strengthen Prime Minister Menachem Begin's hand in the ongoing negotiations at a time when Israel was under pressure to acknowledge some form of Palestinian self-rule and withdrawal from occupied Palestinian territory as part of any deal with Egypt. In the U.S. view, the attack had "refocused the attention of Israel's supporters in the U.S. from the peace process to concern for Israel's security."¹² Worried that Israel's "overreaction" in invading Lebanon might derail the negotiations, President Carter insisted upon Israel's immediate withdrawal.¹³

Significantly, while the United States consulted with Israel on the wording of UNSCR 425, it "informed rather than consulted" Tel Aviv about the establishment of UNIFIL, incurring some displeasure.¹⁴ The United States also rejected Israel's pleas to postpone the voting session for Resolution 425 until Foreign Minister Moshe Dayan reached New York; meanwhile, the United Kingdom, the UNSC's rotating president for March, used its powers to prevent procedural delays

to the “utmost.”¹⁵ Increasing the pressure, Carter and Vance invoked Israel’s clear violation of the U.S. Arms Export Control Act (which states that all U.S. military aid not used for strictly defensive purposes would automatically be cut),¹⁶ while Carter “instructed the State Department to prepare a UNSC resolution condemning Israel’s action” in the event of its non-compliance with U.S. demands.¹⁷

Washington’s near-exclusive focus on securing Israel’s compliance, however, revealed the limits of its understanding of the larger Arab-Israeli picture and its consequences for Lebanon. For example, the United States attempted to exclude the PLO from the UNSC debates on the resolution, yet it was the PLO’s very exclusion from the peace process that had led it to launch the 11 March attack in the first place.¹⁸ As Abu Jihad, the PLO’s second-in-command, noted, “we [wanted] to show that there will never be peace in the Middle East without the Palestinians.”¹⁹ In the end, the PLO did participate in the UNSC debate, but only because, on 17 March, Kuwait called for a vote on the subject within the UNSC, which carried ten to one (the United States) with four abstentions.

In the course of the UNSC deliberations, four main positions competed for international recognition on the ground.

THE POSITION OF THE PALESTINIAN RESISTANCE: LEBANON AS A LEGITIMATE BASE OF OPERATIONS

The PLO had major reservations about Resolution 425, first because it failed to condemn explicitly Israel’s “vindictive and indiscriminate” aggression, and second because it addressed only a “derivative” issue instead of seeking a “solution dealing with the root and heart of the tragedy in the Middle East—namely, the question of Palestine and denial of the inalienable national rights of the Palestinian people.”²⁰

The PLO interventions, while calling for Israel’s immediate withdrawal from Lebanon, insisted on the legitimacy of the Palestinian armed struggle and on its right to remain in the south; after all, according to the PLO’s UN observer, the Palestinians had been “driven” into Lebanon by Israel: “they did not go there of their own choice.”²¹ This position was backed by a number of Arab and non-Arab states: Qatar, for instance, stressed that the Palestinian struggle to “liberate their homeland is a just struggle carried out in self-defense to reclaim their usurped homeland.”²² Concerning UNIFIL, the PLO was not opposed to it per se since the presence of the UN force did not negate the legitimacy of its armed struggle against Israel.

The PLO position on its right to resist from bases in southern Lebanon is perfectly summarized in its response to a Lebanese special parliamentary committee’s April 1978 call for a complete halt of guerrilla action and the dissolution of non-state armed forces: “The Palestinian armed presence and action,” the statement read, “have a [pan-Arab] character and role in the Arab-‘Israeli’ conflict and are not the private internal affair of this Arab country or that . . . and no one has the right to decree this fateful national issue as long as Zionist occupation of Arab land persists.”²³

THE POSITION OF THE LEBANESE STATE: RESTORE SOVEREIGNTY

The Lebanese government position as communicated to the UNSC was as follows: (a) Lebanon was in no way connected to any of the Palestinian operations against Israel; (b) Lebanon was not

responsible for the presence of Palestinian bases in southern Lebanon (particularly in light of Israel's rejection of ADF deployment there in 1976) and had tried its utmost to control the situation on the ground through various agreements; and (c) the only viable UN response to Israel's invasion was to compel Israel to withdraw its forces immediately and to allow the Lebanese government to exercise its authority over its entire territory.²⁴ Lebanon's position enjoyed the sympathy and support of both UN Secretary General Kurt Waldheim and U.S. President Carter.

For the Beirut government, Lebanese sovereignty was threatened equally by Israel's long-held aspirations to Lebanese land and waters and by the Palestinian armed presence that simultaneously attracted Israeli attacks and radicalized opposition groups within the LNM. Israel's withdrawal therefore would have to be accompanied by the removal of Palestinian fighters, who would be barred from attacking Israel from positions in Lebanon. Ghassan Tuani, Lebanon's ambassador to the UN at the time, summed up his government's main objective as follows: "to preserve Lebanon's territorial integrity and restore its sovereignty, without allowing that goal to be contingent upon a settlement of the complex Middle East Question."²⁵ Separating the fate of southern Lebanon from the larger Middle East peace process has long been a key element of the Lebanese state position. As Foreign Minister Fouad Boutros had emphasized in his September 1977 speech to the UN General Assembly, fragile Lebanon could not withstand the transformation of its south into the sole active war zone of a regional war in which Lebanon was a victim. The invasion was the most recent example of this victimhood: in Ambassador Tuani's words, "Once again Lebanon pays the price!"²⁶

Underlying this discourse was Lebanon's delicate confessional balance. The Sarkis administration was keen to support President Carter's plan for a comprehensive settlement in the hopes of averting *tawteen*—the permanent re-settlement of the some four hundred thousand officially registered Palestinian refugees in Lebanon, the vast majority of whom were Sunni Muslims—which would seriously disrupt that balance, creating social instability and threatening Christian dominance.²⁷ For Tuani, all Lebanon could do in such a situation was to "go on pleading with its friends, and appealing to the conscience of the world."²⁸ In this official view, Lebanon's fate would be determined solely by the will of the great powers. The notion of building a "strong state" with a well-equipped army capable of protecting its citizens from foreign forces was unthinkable. Instead, the Lebanese army would be used for domestic purposes—overseeing the separation of warring militias—rather than defending Lebanon's borders against Israeli incursions, as the LNM had insisted.

For all these reasons, Lebanon more than any other party welcomed the deployment of UNIFIL, which in its view could serve as an international proxy making possible the reassertion of its authority and sovereignty in the south and a return to the Christian-dominated internal Lebanese status quo threatened by the Palestinians and their LMN allies.²⁹ Thus, just as Syria's deployment (as the ADF) in Lebanon served to check the PLO, and just as Israel's "red lines" served to check Syria, so UNIFIL's role would be to check Israel and assist the government in "re-Lebanizing rather than institutionalizing the South."³⁰ Since the government did not have the means, or possibly even the legitimacy, to impose its will in southern Lebanon, where the long neglected Shi'a community was now demanding a more equitable distribution of power and state resources, it wanted to use the UN as a vehicle to do so instead.

THE CHRISTIAN RIGHT/LEBANESE FORCES: ESTABLISH A "NEW LEBANON"

The Christian Right/LF were not party to the UNSC debates. However, given their power on the ground, a full analysis of positions concerning UNIFIL must necessarily include theirs. For Bashir Gemayel, the Christian-dominated government and its institutions had been "infiltrated from the inside" to the point of having become the "enemy to our cause."³¹ The vision he preached of a "New Lebanon" of "free" citizens, "effective" institutions, and an army capable of enforcing sovereignty over all Lebanese territory in principle was not unlike that of the official government.³² However, he insisted that this goal should be achieved not through reliance on the international community but through a proactive "war of liberation" led by his militias.³³ For him, the Cairo Agreement "cost us the South," and the UNSC was "delusional" in thinking that the Lebanese crisis could be solved by a simple resolution.³⁴

With regard to UNIFIL, whereas the government wanted it to help restore the status quo ante of unchallenged Christian dominance, Gemayel wanted it to help the LF achieve their militaristic vision: the expulsion of both the Syrian troops and the "600,000 foreign refugees on our land."³⁵ According to Gemayel, UNIFIL's mission, confined to the south and in his view intended mainly to prevent a Syrian-Israeli confrontation, was "meaningless," since once UNIFIL (inevitably) withdrew, the south would "once again be uncontrolled" and all of Lebanon would experience "a million and one catastrophes."³⁶ The "problem" of the south, in other words, required finding a solution for the entire country. He thus called for UNIFIL's mandate to be "extended all over Lebanon" so that the "Lebanese state [could] be made strong . . . and the Lebanese army be reconstituted."³⁷ In the meantime, UNIFIL was not there to "remove" the Palestinians from the south nor to protect it from occupation. This was the task of the "real" Lebanese army—Haddad's SLA, not the regular armed forces, which Bashir condemned as Syrian proxies.³⁸

ISRAEL'S POSITION: SOUTHERN LEBANON AS BUFFER ZONE AGAINST "TERRORISTS"

The official Israeli position was that the 1978 invasion was a case of justified retaliatory self-defense in light of the PLO attack on the Haifa-Tel Aviv highway, which had killed thirty-seven people. In fact, however, the raid was a pretext to give the Begin government a "strong public relations basis upon which an already urgently needed military operation could be launched" to clear the border of PLO and LMN forces.³⁹ Begin, who had proclaimed that the SLA was needed to save southern Lebanon's Christians from "genocide,"⁴⁰ authorized the invasion both as retaliation and to create new rules in southern Lebanon. Throughout the UNSC debates, Israel stressed that the PLO was a "terrorist" organization that threatened not only the security of Israel and its Christian Lebanese allies, but also Lebanon's sovereignty.

Israel strongly criticized Resolution 425 as "inadequate and sorely lacking"⁴¹ because it did not explicitly ban "terrorists" from returning to southern Lebanon, which "includes the largest concentration of terrorists in the world."⁴² Israel's UN ambassador, Chaim Herzog, denounced the world body for its "craven submission" to and "even outright support of international terrorism," and quoted from telegrams "received" from Lebanese citizens supporting Israel's invasion. During the debates, Israel repeatedly linked its own interests to Lebanon's, asserting that

the invasion intended to “clear the region of murderers who have terrorized both Lebanese villagers and Israeli civilians for far too long, to destroy their bases, and to ensure they do not return.”⁴³ It further emphasized that Lebanon’s “unity, independence, and sovereignty” could not be restored without the PLO’s removal from the border region;⁴⁴ any return to the status quo ante was unacceptable.

Israel’s declared position on UNSCR 425, similar to the official Lebanese stand, was to re-establish Lebanese state authority in southern Lebanon. Indeed, Israel claimed to want “no more than we should return to being as we were for 20 years: peaceful neighbors along a common border, farming side by side, and living in harmony.”⁴⁵ As for UNIFIL, Israel looked to it for help in incapacitating the PLO and protecting Israel’s self-declared security zone along the border.

* * *

Though Israel had declared upon crossing into Lebanon on 14 March that it would not go beyond a 10 km “security belt,” less than forty-eight hours later, with the UNSC already in session, it pushed on another 19 km up the coast to the Litani River, in a bid to negotiate a “PLO-free zone” south of the river. On 20 March, Israel succeeded in striking a deal with UNIFIL that effectively ceded the entire length of the border area to Haddad’s SLA, with UNIFIL to patrol the “buffer zone” between Haddad’s positions in the security belt and the Litani.⁴⁶ Israel officially accepted the ceasefire the next day, but made clear that it would not fully withdraw until UNIFIL was strong enough to prevent new commando infiltration by the PLO and its Lebanese allies.⁴⁷

PLO Chairman Yasir Arafat officially accepted both the ceasefire and UNIFIL’s presence at the end of March. Having successfully extracted assurances from UNIFIL that Palestinian bases (especially the “Tyre pocket”) would be excluded from its area of operation, he pledged not to attack Israel from UNIFIL areas. In fact, Arafat continued to authorize guerrilla activities in southern Lebanon until UNSG Kurt Waldheim and newly-appointed UNIFIL Commander Emmanuel Erskine visited him in mid-April, thus paving the way for informal recognition of the PLO as a party to the conflict (a contrast to the PLO’s exclusion from the formulation of Resolution 425).⁴⁸ In the meantime, the PLO continued to insist on its right of resistance legitimized by the Cairo Agreement and protected by international law. Under pressure from the United States, Israel withdrew its troops from Lebanon in June 1978. However, rather than handing over key positions near the border to UNIFIL, as required by Resolution 425, it authorized Haddad’s militia to take control of the 10 km wide “free Lebanon” zone and instructed Lebanese army officials to recognize Haddad’s authority along the border. The Lebanese army challenged the Israeli move, and on 31 July 1978, after a meeting informing UNIFIL and Israeli army representatives of its intentions, it dispatched a lightly armed battalion of seven hundred to positions deep in SLA-held territory. Its main goal was to restore Lebanese sovereignty in the south, maintain peace and security there, and prevent any armed movement in its area of responsibility⁴⁹—i.e., to fulfill the remaining terms of Resolution 425. But this force was stopped in its tracks by SLA shelling authorized by Begin himself, despite prior Israeli assurances to the United States and UN that it would accept the Lebanese army deployment.⁵⁰

UNIFIL: Lost in Translation after 1979

After 1979, UNIFIL was effectively marginalized and became, for all intents and purposes, politically irrelevant with regard to both the Arab-Israeli and the internal Lebanese conflicts. It was consequently confined to the purgatory of UNSC inaction: the UNSC neither pulled the plug on the mission nor meaningfully supported it by addressing south Lebanon's core problems. Instead, as former long-serving UNIFIL spokesman Timur Göksel explains, UNIFIL had to implement its mandate and keep the peace "with absolutely no support from anybody" in a deployment area that not only lacked effective state and army presence but was subject to the effects of Lebanon's "triple war": the civil war "southern Lebanon version," the civil war "Beirut version," and the cross-border Palestinian-Israeli war.⁵¹ For much of the early period of its deployment, UNIFIL acted mainly as an interposition force between PLO and SLA forces, often at great cost to its personnel.

THE EARLY PHASE: U.S. RETREAT

As already indicated, the intense U.S. involvement in UNSCR 425 was subordinated to its interest in reaching a Middle East settlement, and once Israel withdrew from Lebanon in June 1978, the Carter administration essentially lost interest. This retreat played a major role in UNIFIL's marginalization, even as the U.S. failure to take the conflict in the south seriously on its own terms opened up space for controversy on precisely on what UNIFIL was there to do.

From the outset, the UN Secretariat was concerned that the UNSC had created an impossible mission for UNIFIL. It was the Secretariat that had insisted on the word "interim" in UNIFIL's name as a way of signaling its uneasiness about the mission's inadequate planning, equipment, and lack of exit strategy, and to reflect its understanding that this would be a short-term project pending the deployment of the Lebanese army southwards. Brian Urquhart, head of UN peacekeeping operations at the time, recalled that he "was strongly opposed to putting a peacekeeping force into the anarchic conditions of southern Lebanon," adding that "none of the conditions which make for a successful peacekeeping operation existed in southern Lebanon."⁵² Urquhart understood what Carter could not, that "southern Lebanon would be a peacekeeper's nightmare."⁵³

In effect, as Washington lost interest in southern Lebanon, so did the UNSC. The major political test for gauging the extent of the UNSC's commitment to and support of UNIFIL was whether or not the Lebanese state, via its army, would be able to deploy to the border region in fulfillment of Resolution 425. This had been a core demand of the Lebanese government, accepted by the PLO (despite resentment of some of its factions), and popular with the largely Shi'a residents of southern Lebanon. Indeed, the Shi'a, mobilized by Imam Musa Sadr, were by then demanding state protection against both the Israelis and the PLO forces, and calling for an end to overall state neglect of the south.⁵⁴

As we have seen, the UNSC failed this first test, having done nothing when the Lebanese army was driven back by the SLA while attempting to deploy in the south following Israel's withdrawal. When the army once again announced its intention to deploy in April 1979, the SLA issued a strong warning that the army unit "operated by" Syria, the PLO, UNIFIL, and the LNM "will not

be allowed to enter the areas close to our lines.”⁵⁵ Before the army could deploy, the SLA closed all roads used by UNIFIL and proceeded to shell UNIFIL units throughout the south and even its headquarters in Naqura. Despite UN protest to Israel, there was little political consequence, since Washington did not intervene in any meaningful way.

It was during this period that UNIFIL Force Commander Erskine came to understand that Israel had no intention to honor its official rhetoric and be replaced by the Lebanese army and UNIFIL, but that it was in southern Lebanon “to stay.”⁵⁶ For Israel and the SLA, the PLO and the LNM were no longer a military threat, whereas UNIFIL “had become the most dangerous factor” in the area because of its “demands and its ambitions to take control of the security belt in the name of the Lebanese government.”⁵⁷ In other words: UNIFIL’s mandate to restore Lebanon’s sovereignty in the south—while implicitly recognizing the right of resistance to continue—threatened Israel’s plans to crush the resistance forces and impose a new, friendlier Lebanese government. Indeed, the UNSG’s reports from 1979 to 1981 “leave little doubt” that the greatest obstacle to the implementation of UNIFIL’s mandate was less the “armed elements” (that is, non-state Lebanese and Palestinian resistance forces) than the Israeli-backed SLA.⁵⁸ Even the UNSC (for example, in its Resolution 444 of January 1979) “deplored” the “lack of co-operation, particularly on Israel’s part, with UNIFIL’s efforts to fully implement its mandate including Israel’s assistance to irregular armed groups in southern Lebanon.”⁵⁹

The Carter administration, meanwhile, though turning a blind eye (after June 1978) to Israel’s intransigence in southern Lebanon, did continue—in the interest of overall Arab-Israeli peace and regional stability—to use diplomatic channels to defuse tensions between the SLA and UNIFIL. The coming to power of Ronald Reagan in 1981, however, set the stage for the militarization of U.S. policy in the region and hardened Israeli plans in Lebanon. In the meantime, the SLA continued to consolidate the “security zone” on Israel’s behalf, strictly controlling UN movement therein and forcing UNIFIL to focus on humanitarian and record-keeping responsibilities.⁶⁰ Following a U.S.-mediated ceasefire in July 1981, for example, the UN backed up PLO claims that it was adhering to the terms of the ceasefire and “not violating it at all.”⁶¹

REAGAN AND THE JUNE 1982 ISRAELI INVASION

UNIFIL’s political marginalization, effectively begun in June 1978, was completed with Israel’s June 1982 invasion: UNIFIL was simply “brushed aside contemptuously”⁶² as Israeli forces pushed all the way to Beirut, intent upon eliminating the PLO, installing Bashir Gemayel as Lebanese president, and securing (via the conclusion of a peace treaty with the new Lebanese government) its hegemonic position in the south.⁶³

At the UNSC, Israel pushed the United States to veto a draft resolution extending UNIFIL’s area of operation north of the Litani and station UN military observers in Beirut.⁶⁴ The Reagan administration blamed the veto on the draft’s “fatal flaw” of not calling for the “elimination from Beirut and elsewhere of the presence of armed Palestinian elements.”⁶⁵ UNIFIL’s Force Commander, William O’Callaghan, had earlier cabled UN headquarters stating that UNIFIL could deploy two-thirds of its battalions to Beirut and was overall “ready to play its role and to move . . . rapidly and decisively.”⁶⁶ Instead, UNIFIL’s mandate in the midst of a major invasion was extended by only two months rather than the customary six.

Following a request by the Lebanese government, the Reagan administration put together, in August 1982, a Multinational Force (MNF) initially comprising two thousand American, French, and Italian combat forces under U.S. leadership. The MNF, which did not have UNSC authorization, had a mandate to supervise the withdrawal of the PLO armed forces and help restore Lebanese sovereignty in Beirut. Following the Sabra and Shatila massacres in September 1982, the MNF was reinforced as an “interposition force,” doubling in size.⁶⁷ France, meanwhile, had tried to resurrect a draft resolution (vetoed by the Soviet Union) calling for a single, stronger UN force with a mandate to cover both the south and Beirut.

Thus sidelined, UNIFIL, for the next eighteen years, would operate under extraordinary circumstances for a peacekeeping operation: namely in an area under direct (Israeli) occupation. No longer permitted to perform peacekeeping work, UNIFIL concentrated on the vital, if secondary, tasks of emergency relief, humanitarian intervention, and record keeping, with its mandate usually renewed every six months.

This period was significant for closer U.S. coordination with Israel and stronger U.S. support for Israel’s narrative on UNIFIL. Whereas the Carter administration had been clear about Israel’s obligations under UNSCR 425, including that UNIFIL should be accorded full cooperation, the Reagan administration, for both Cold War and ideological calculations, accepted Israel’s contention that its security and Lebanon’s sovereignty were equally threatened by resistance forces in the south. The joint Israeli-U.S. objective was thus to disarm the PLO by force while strengthening Lebanon’s “sovereignty”—re-conceptualized here to mean Lebanon’s right to secure its border against resistance forces (not Israel). This vision was concretized in the U.S.-brokered May 17 Agreement between Israel and Lebanon in 1983. The agreement provided for a “security zone” policed by a limited Lebanese force into which the SLA would be integrated, effectively putting southern Lebanon, in the words of Richard Norton, “under Israeli control.”⁶⁸ The agreement also specifically tied Israel’s withdrawal to that of the Syrian army, a clear contradiction of UNSCR 425, which placed no conditions on such a withdrawal. Under such a vision, UNIFIL, given its mandate and the limits that the UN Secretariat had imposed on its use of force, had no role to play.

THE EMERGENCE OF THE LEBANESE SHI’A RESISTANCE

Despite the fact that the last remnant of the PLO was expelled from Lebanon in 1983, the Israeli-U.S. joint strategy in Lebanon unraveled under the combined impact of Bashir Gemayel’s assassination in September 1982, the departure of the MNF in February 1984 following a series of deadly car bombs against U.S. and French bases in Beirut, and Lebanon’s abrogation in March 1984 of the May 17 Agreement. The emergence of a native, southern Lebanese, and largely Shi’a resistance movement not only re-engaged the south in the struggle on the ground for economic and social justice, but also challenged what had become the prevailing attitude vis-à-vis southern Lebanon (and implicitly the interpretation of UNIFIL’s mandate), namely the irrelevance of the local population and acquiescence in Israel’s de facto control.

The changing mood within the local community, whose interests had long been ignored, went largely unnoticed by the various actors. The Lebanese state had been more or less absent from the south both in security and developmental terms. The government of Amin Gemayel, elected

president in late 1982 to replace his brother Bashir, continued to ignore the increasingly important Shi'a community.⁶⁹ The Israeli occupation forces also dismissed the emerging Shi'a movement, failing to understand that popular support for the PLO's exit from the south did not translate into pro-Israel sentiments.⁷⁰ Indeed, it can be argued that precisely because they were effectively ignored by the UNSC and left to their own devices on the ground, some within UNIFIL were the first to appreciate the changes taking place in the Shi'a community, well before the other major parties did so after the civil war ended. UNIFIL's sympathy and expressions of concern, even if at least partly motivated by self-interest, eventually brought them the good will of both Amal, the main Shi'a political force in the early 1980s, and most of the local population. As Timur Göksel remarked in reference to this period, "UNIFIL's biggest success . . . was its relations with the people."⁷¹

As Hizballah, under the leadership of Hassan Nasrallah, gradually took on the mantle of the national resistance movement during the 1990s, it sought to impose a meaning of Lebanese "sovereignty" that entailed not only the expulsion of Israeli occupation troops, but also southern Lebanon's return to the larger "resistance" movement against Israel, thus making Lebanon, as a whole, a core player in the Arab-Israeli conflict. As a Lebanese resistance movement rooted in the Shi'i political re-awakening and the religious militarization model of the Iranian Revolution, Hizballah's forceful linking of apparently separate narratives—sovereignty for Lebanon and resistance against Israel—was to become hegemonic in an area virtually abandoned by the Lebanese government, the PLO, the United States, and the international community (as represented by the UNSC). Nasrallah—himself from southern Lebanon, in contrast to the earlier Beqa'a-based Hizballah leaders—understood that UNIFIL was not necessarily an enemy, and appointed the first official liaison to UNIFIL.⁷²

The 1989 Taif Accord ended the Lebanese civil war with a recalibration of the sectarian balance (somewhat reducing Christian preeminence) and established Syria and Saudi Arabia as the main regional political players in Lebanon. In so doing, it effectively confirmed the demise of the official Christian understanding of the southern Lebanon question. A post-war consensus emerged under Syrian hegemony (which in effect masked the absence of a Lebanese consensus) that gave Hizballah official resistance status under the terms both of Taif and UNSCR 425. Moreover, throughout the post-1983 period, after Israel had been forced to withdraw from the suburbs of Beirut to its so-called "security zone" south of the Litani, UNIFIL continued to observe the long-standing UN policy that recognized both Lebanon's right of resistance against occupation forces and the idea that only a "just, lasting and comprehensive peace in the Middle East" would solve the root of the conflict. According to an April 1985 statement by UNSG Boutros Boutros-Ghali,

UNIFIL, for obvious reasons, has no right to impede Lebanese acts of resistance against the occupying force, nor does it have the mandate to prevent countermeasures. In these circumstances, the men of UNIFIL have done their utmost to mitigate violence, protect the civilian population, and to reduce acts of reprisal to a minimum.⁷³

The UNSG reiterated this formula in the aftermath of Israel's April 1996 "Grapes of Wrath" attack on Lebanon.⁷⁴ Furthermore, the U.S.-brokered ceasefire agreement between Hizballah and Israel (known as the "April Understanding") recognized the inherent right of "armed groups" to resist

and set up rules for Hizballah and Israel not to attack civilian areas.⁷⁵ The UN later endorsed this arrangement.

Thus, by the late 1990s, the 1978 positions of the PLO, the LF, and the Christian-dominated Lebanese state on Resolution 425 and UNIFIL's role had been defeated, leaving Hizballah's interpretation of "sovereignty" and "resistance" within both the terms of the resolution and the larger Arab-Israeli framework dominant. UNIFIL had also accepted this reality, and sought increasingly to cooperate with the new de facto authority in the south.

* * *

Israel's dramatic withdrawal under fire from Lebanon in May 2000 ushered in a new stage in the conflict over UNIFIL's mandate and role.⁷⁶ On 18 June 2000, two days after certifying Israel's withdrawal from southern Lebanon, the UNSC issued a presidential statement endorsing the withdrawal, adding:

The Security Council calls on the Government of Lebanon to ensure the return of its effective authority and presence in the south. . . . The Council notes that the *United Nations cannot assume law and order functions which are properly the responsibility of the Government of Lebanon* [emphasis added]. . . . It calls upon Lebanon to proceed with the deployment of the Lebanese armed forces as soon as possible, with the assistance of UNIFIL, into the Lebanese territory recently vacated by Israel.⁷⁷

However, Lebanon, still under the control of Syria, which did not want an end to the southern Lebanon conflict until its own predicament in the Golan Heights was also resolved, officially disputed the UN's certification. It claimed that Israel remained in violation of Resolution 425 since it continued to occupy parts of Lebanon (i.e. the Sheba'a farms area) and was still holding Lebanese prisoners in Israeli jails. The Lebanese government further took the position that "so long as there is no comprehensive peace with Israel, the [Lebanese] army would not act as a broader guard for Israel and would not be deployed to the border" as per UN demands.⁷⁸ Syria and Hizballah stifled internal discussion in Lebanon about Resolution 425 and Lebanese army deployment, while, internationally, Washington was distracted by the Israeli-Palestinian and Israeli-Syrian negotiation tracks. Israel, for its part, considered the withdrawal unilateral, while the other major parties to the conflict considered southern Lebanon to be connected to the larger Arab-Israeli war.

Nonetheless, a shift had taken place: for the first time, the UN and Israeli positions had converged in the conviction that, with Israel having fulfilled its obligations under Resolution 425, it was now time for the Lebanese army to deploy in the south.

From Resolution 425 to Resolution 1701: UNIFIL's New Mandate

During the five years that followed Israel's withdrawal from the south in 2000, the border zone was "quieter than it had been for the past thirty years,"⁷⁹ and UNIFIL wound down its activities in anticipation of ending its mission. The peacekeeping force was reduced to a skeletal force of around two thousand troops awaiting disbanding, with the UNSC adamant that all that remained

of its mandate under Resolution 425 was the return of Lebanon's authority via the deployment of the Lebanese army to southern Lebanon.⁸⁰ Nonetheless, this calm masked the reality that the conflict between Hizballah—given legitimacy in official terms by the Syrian-backed Lebanese state since Taif (though in reality contested within Lebanon)—and Israel simmered. Hizballah continued to stockpile weapons and reinforce its positions, while Israel remained determined to prevent the Hizballah model of resistance from being replicated elsewhere, notably in Palestine.⁸¹ In short, Israel could not allow Hizballah's narrative of Resolution 425 to continue to prevail after its UN-certified withdrawal in 2000.

Israel was given the opportunity to reassert its deterrence on 12 July 2006, when Hizballah crossed the border and attacked a nearby army patrol, capturing two soldiers. The ensuing war, which lasted almost exactly one month, ended with the UNSC unanimously passing Resolution 1701 on 11 August, some twenty-eight years after it had adopted Resolution 425.

The new resolution significantly beefed up UNIFIL. In order to “supplement and enhance” the peacekeeping body in terms of “number, equipment, and scope of operations,” Resolution 1701 authorized an increase in force strength to a maximum of fifteen thousand troops.⁸² It endowed the new force with more active rules of engagement, authorizing it to “take all necessary action . . . as it deems within its capabilities, to ensure that its area of operations is not utilized for hostile activities of any kind.”⁸³ For the first time in UN peacekeeping history, a UN-led Maritime Task Force was deployed to patrol Lebanese territorial waters in search of illegal arms shipments.⁸⁴ The new UNIFIL, largely composed of and led by European Union member-states, was also supported by a newly established military strategic office in New York and a vastly expanded UN political office in Beirut, headed by its own UN under-secretary and charged with producing quarterly follow-up reports on the implementation of Resolution 1701.⁸⁵

All this endowed the new force with the budget, political commitment, and material support that the older UNIFIL had sorely lacked. UNIFIL thus became “robust” in line with its new political priorities, namely ensuring the extension of Lebanon's exclusive state authority and monopoly of weapons in the south for the first time in nearly three decades.

Such a significant upgrade was possible because, in the UNSC deliberations over Resolution 1701, in contrast to those over 425, the U.S., Israeli, and UN positions converged. The political context in which the two resolutions were negotiated also differed: instead of a U.S. push for Arab-Israeli peace in 1979, the context of 2006 was a U.S. “war on terror” in which “terrorism” was imagined as a joint U.S.-Israeli concern.

Indeed, UNSCR 1701 purposely did away with the Arab-Israeli frame that had been the basis of UNSCR 425, even if the earlier resolution had not meaningfully engaged with the wider conflict. Instead, and in line with U.S. and Israeli demands, Resolution 1701 located the “problem” of southern Lebanon in the weakness of the Lebanese state that, it seemed, was both caused and exploited by Hizballah, which in turn threatened both Lebanese sovereignty and Israeli security, now widely seen as one and the same thing. UNIFIL's core tasks thus shifted from those associated with being an interposition force between Palestinian fighters and Israeli proxies on an active front of the Arab-Israeli conflict (under Resolution 425) to those associated with a force charged with building the capacity of the Lebanese state, including its army, and forcefully asserting Lebanon's sovereignty at the expense of Hizballah and any other armed resistance force (under Resolution 1701).⁸⁶

Specifically, UNIFIL's enhanced mandate included: supervising the "cessation of hostilities" between Israel and Hizballah; assisting in humanitarian operations and the return of displaced persons to their villages in southern Lebanon; ensuring Israel's withdrawal from Lebanese territory in parallel to Lebanese army deployment; and generally supporting the Lebanese government in reasserting its authority over southern Lebanon. More controversially, the mandate now included helping the Lebanese army to keep southern Lebanon "free of any armed personnel, assets and weapons" (other than those held by the army itself and UNIFIL) and "securing" Lebanon's "borders and other entry points" to prevent illegal arms shipments into the country.⁸⁷

Despite the enhanced UNIFIL mandate and force strength, however, the period between the new force's deployment in late summer 2006 and the conclusion in May 2008 of the Doha Agreement—a truce between opposing Lebanese coalitions that paved the way for the election of a new president, the creation of a national unity government, and (at least temporarily) relative stability—witnessed a renewed and at times violent struggle to give meaning to Resolution 1701 and interpret UNIFIL's new terms of reference.⁸⁸

The struggle over the terms of 1701 and UNIFIL during this period often replicated the earlier struggle over 425. The Israeli position on 1701 saw UNIFIL's main task as disarming Hizballah and pacifying any resistance in southern Lebanon—just as it had in 1978 with regard to the PLO. In both periods, when Israel felt it was losing influence, it turned to large-scale invasions (1982 and 2006), with a U.S.-backed interposition force as a fallback (MNF in 1982 and a mooted NATO force in 2006) tasked to disarm the existing resistance groups. The Lebanese state position, at least after it became clear that Israel could not win decisively on the battlefield, largely reproduced that of the Sarkis government three decades earlier: it appealed to the UN to help the state—portrayed once again as a victim in a war it did not want—somehow extricate itself from the Arab-Israeli conflict and impose its authority in southern Lebanon against both Israeli occupation forces and what it saw as non-state militias (Hizballah and Palestinian armed elements). Some of the more hawkish leaders of Lebanon's March 14 coalition, established in the wake of the February 2005 assassination of former Lebanese prime minister Rafiq Hariri, echoed Bashir Gemayel's narratives from the 1970s in their calls for greater self-reliance in building a sovereign Lebanon equally free of foreign (read: Syrian and Iranian/Hizballah) influence and of armed militias threatening the state (in this case, Hizballah rather than the PLO).

For its part, Hizballah, which emerged politically strengthened from the 2006 war, inherited the PLO's position as the main resistance force in southern Lebanon, except that Hizballah was far less vulnerable by virtue of its native status and the support of a newly empowered local population. The basis of Hizballah's position rested on blocking any interpretation of 1701 as a state-building resolution and of UNIFIL as a peace enforcement operation. For Hizballah, then, UNIFIL was welcome as a "guest" organization whose main aim was to provide protection and security for the people of southern Lebanon after four decades of Israeli occupation.

* * *

The new UNIFIL's attempts early on to enforce its "robust" rules of engagement, for instance by forcibly entering Hizballah safe houses in pursuit of weapons, led to high tensions both with Hizballah and the local population. As a result, the UN force went from

being perceived by the local population as little more than a “friendly UNIFIL” who “shared their lives in tough times under very difficult circumstances,”⁸⁹ to a “robust UNIFIL” intent on disarming the Hizballah-led resistance and helping the United States impose what U.S. Secretary of State Condoleezza Rice memorably proclaimed—in the midst of the 2006 war—its “new Middle East” project.⁹⁰

Ultimately, though, the tension between the new UNIFIL and the local population serves to remind us that the details of UNIFIL’s mandate and rules of engagement are less relevant than the political context in which UNIFIL is deployed. In the final analysis, UNIFIL’s three-decade deployment in Lebanon illustrates that UN resolutions are useful barometers for gauging shifting political currents and tensions. In Lebanon, these UN resolutions became more important as sites of contestation over meanings of sovereignty, security, and resistance as the United States shifted its position from an internationally accepted understanding of Westphalian sovereignty and traditional peacekeeping under Resolution 425, to a “post-Westphalian” understanding that advocates the international re-engineering of the state and imposes a particular definition of security and sovereignty. In Lebanon’s divided polity, the deployment of a “robust” peacekeeping force could be seen as a means toward such ends.

The UN resolutions lost their importance as U.S. interest in them faded and the United States accepted the prevailing status quo, whether because of more important regional dynamics (as was the case for Carter with regard to 425) or apparent political defeat (as in the case of the Bush administration with regard to 1701). What has happened over the three decades of UNIFIL’s existence is that as the dominant international understanding of southern Lebanon’s predicament shifted from one contextualized by the Arab-Israeli conflict to one anchored in the weakness of the state, in line with Israeli and LF/March 14 positions, the nature of the resistance in southern Lebanon has also evolved. Under the regime of the new UNIFIL, Hizballah struggles to impose a clear delineation between internal political bickering in Lebanon and the battle over southern Lebanon as the most important gateway to sustain the Arab-Israeli war. This contradiction and contestation co-exist within Resolution 1701 in a way that they did not in 425.

UNIFIL’s first force commander, reflecting in 1989 on his experience of peacekeeping in Lebanon, wrote that “the story has no ending.”⁹¹ Two decades later, with the Arab-Israeli conflict far from resolved and with the concepts of resistance, sovereignty, and security still heavily contested, both in Lebanon and in the region, there is little indication that Erskine’s bleak assessment has changed.

About the Author

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